Weighing a SF Relocation Offer Against a Partner's Career

First-Principles Analysis

11 October 2026

Professional Strategic Analysis

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Executive Summary

Recommendation: Treat this as a sequence rather than a binary choice: first try to negotiate remote work or a reduced in-office cadence on the existing offer, since that path captures nearly all of the financial and career upside with the least risk (chain C4); if that's refused, decline while explicitly using the offer as leverage with your current employer (chain C4), rather than defaulting to full relocation — which scores weakest of all five options tested (chain C4), driven mainly by partner-career and relationship risk (chains C2, C4).

Band (from §6): LOW.

Would change it: Confirming whether the partner's career truly has no Bay-Area-portable path, since that is the single swing factor (chain C2); and getting the offer's actual equity-vesting terms and in-office-cadence commitment in writing (chains C1, C3).

1. Problem Essence

Core problem: Should the user pursue, negotiate, decline, or restructure the SF Bay Area offer (relocation + 3-day/week in-office hybrid, +$70,000/yr total comp) given a partner whose established Portland-based career currently has no remote option — in a way that protects the household's real finances, the partner's career, and the relationship, while preserving as much reversibility as the known facts allow?

Success criteria:

- SC1: The answer states the cost-of-living- and tax-adjusted real financial delta, not just the nominal $70,000 headline figure, checkable against §4/§6.
- SC2: The answer names which specific unknowns about the partner's career and the relationship are load-bearing enough to flip the recommendation, rather than assuming them away.
- SC3: The recommended path preserves as much optionality/reversibility as the given facts allow, rather than defaulting to the single most dramatic option (full relocation) by default.
- SC4: The answer does not silently resolve the decision on the user's behalf where the given facts are insufficient to do so — it states exactly what additional information would resolve it, as direct questions.

2. Assumptions Table

Type	Accept	Challenge	Discard
physical law	0	0	0
current constraint	2	3	0
convention	0	2	1
untested belief	0	8	0

Shading darkens with count.
An untyped (legacy) row appears only for assumptions with no type.

Assumption	Type	Treatment	Verdict	Verification
A-1: The $70K total-comp delta (base+equity) is accurate as described and realized starting immediately	current constraint	Record expiry/ condition: verify against the actual offer letter	Challenge — base/ equity split and vesting schedule unconfirmed	unverified — flagged (feeds GT-10?, chain C1)
A-2: Partner's career has literally zero remote option and zero viable Bay-Area equivalent (not merely "hasn't been offered remotely")	current constraint	Record expiry conditions — what would have to be true for this to no longer hold	Challenge — "no remote option" could mean several different things with very different consequences	unverified — flagged (feeds GT-12?, chain C2)
A-3: The 3-day/week hybrid cadence will remain stable for the user's tenure	convention	Explicitly challenge before use	Challenge — directionally contradicted by GT-5? (Bay Area RTO cadence tightening industry-wide)	unverified — flagged
A-4: Full relocation is the only way to satisfy the 3-day in-office requirement; no commuter/trial arrangement exists	convention	Explicitly challenge before use	Challenge — no citation found on whether this employer permits a distributed/commuter arrangement	unverified — flagged
A-5: Once executed, this decision (quitting, relocating, partner leaving their job) is reversible within a reasonable time at low cost	current constraint	Record expiry conditions	Challenge — tech employment itself reverses easily, but partner-career disruption and relationship strain do not	unverified — flagged
A-6: The relationship can sustain the stress of whichever path is chosen	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — unassessable by this analysis; only the couple can verify this	unverified — flagged; no external source can supply this
A-7: The SF Bay Area has a substantially higher cost of living than Portland	current constraint	Record expiry conditions (could narrow with continued remote-driven migration)	Accept — supported directly by GT-1, GT-2, read at source	read-at-source — see GT-1, GT-2
A-8: California's combined state+federal tax burden is higher than Oregon's at the user's likely income level ("CA taxes will eat the raise")	convention	Explicitly challenge before use	Discard — contradicted by GT-7/GT-8 (read at source): Oregon's compressed brackets tax the same income more heavily than California's broader brackets at $100K-$200K	read-at-source — see GT-7, GT-8
A-9: The equity portion of the $70K delta is liquid, realizable value comparable to cash in hand	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — equity typically vests over years with forfeiture/ volatility risk; vesting schedule unknown	unverified — flagged
A-10: The current Portland remote role and its comp trajectory are themselves stable and not at risk	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — no information given on current employer's stability, raise cadence, or promotion trajectory	unverified — flagged

Assumption	Type	Treatment	Verdict	Verification
A-11: Declining or countering with this offer carries negligible professional/ reputational risk at the current employer	current constraint	Record expiry conditions	Accept — generally low-risk in tech to decline or leverage an outside offer; an internal counter can occasionally sour if handled poorly	unverified — flagged; general industry pattern, not independently sourced
A-12 (surfaced by inversion, §2 narrative): a necessary precondition for "accept" being clearly correct is that the partner has a credible, explicitly-agreed path forward (remote work, an equivalent Bay-Area role, or a pause they are genuinely enthusiastic about)	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — not yet established; load-bearing per the inversion analysis below	unverified — flagged
A-13 (surfaced by Assumption Audit on chain C1)	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — the $70,000 figure is assumed to be an ongoing annual run-rate, not a one-time signing bonus or front-loaded equity grant; not distinguished in the facts given	unverified — flagged
A-14 (surfaced by Assumption Audit on chain C2)	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — if the partner's income were lost or reduced, the loss plausibly exceeds the user's own $43,000-$50,000/yr net individual gain (chain C1); unconfirmed, depends entirely on the partner's unspecified field	unverified — flagged
A-15 (surfaced by Assumption Audit on chain C3's 2nd-order extension)	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — if in-office cadence tightens later, no renegotiation, grandfathering, or exit accommodation is assumed to be offered	unverified — flagged
A-16 (surfaced by Assumption Audit on chain C4)	untested belief	Verify or flag	Challenge — the trade-off's preference-based criterion scores (partner continuity, relationship risk, quality of life) reflect a reasonable default reading of the stated facts, not a measured fact; the user should re-score these against their own judgment	unverified — flagged; see chain C4

Inversion applied (Phase 2 companion technique). Claim stated: *"Accepting the SF offer is the correct decision for this household."* Inverted: *"Accepting the SF offer is not correct — it leaves the household worse off, financially or relationally, than staying."* Failure-guaranteeing conditions enumerated:

1. The partner's career cannot continue in any form (remote, Bay-Area-equivalent, or a paused-with-recovery-path) without major, unrecoverable loss of income or seniority.
2. The relationship cannot tolerate the stress of relocation, long-distance commuting, or the partner's career sacrifice.
3. The $70K comp delta, once equity liquidity and COL are accounted for, turns out materially smaller or negative in practice.
4. The in-office cadence increases beyond 3 days/week shortly after the move, removing the flexibility that made the deal tolerable.
5. The decision is effectively irreversible — e.g. the partner's field penalizes a career gap or relocation such that returning to Portland doesn't restore what was given up.

Necessary preconditions for an "obvious yes" (derived from the inversion, each a definite assertion rather than a topic): the partner has a credible, explicitly-agreed path forward (A-12); the relationship is explicitly discussed and both partners are genuinely on board, not merely acquiescing (A-6); the financial delta is confirmed real — vesting schedule known, equity realistic (A-1, A-9); the 3-day cadence is reasonably likely to hold, or the household has a pre-agreed exit plan if it does not (A-3, A-4). Conditions 1 and 2 above (and their corresponding preconditions A-12 and A-6) are tagged **load-bearing**: the recommendation in §6 does not survive either being false. Conditions 3-5 matter but a shortfall there is more survivable if 1 and 2 hold. Symmetrically, an "obvious yes to accept" would require the mirror image of all four preconditions holding with high confidence — which the given facts do not establish either way.

3. Ground Truths

- **GT-1** Overall cost-of-living index: San Francisco = 100, Portland = 66 (Portland ~34.0% less expensive overall), on this tool's own national-average-pegged scale — source: movenumbers.com, "san-francisco-ca-vs-portland-or" comparison page; read-at-source: "Overall cost of living index" table, fetched and read directly. Label: modeled calculator index, not a government-measured statistic.
- **GT-2** Modeled monthly housing spend: San Francisco $9,771 vs. Portland $4,704 (diff. $5,068/mo, 51.9%); modeled 2-bedroom rent: San Francisco $3,570 vs. Portland $1,900 — source: movenumbers.com, same page; read-at-source: "Housing/rent figures" section, fetched and read directly. Label: modeled estimate, not a measured rent-registry figure.
- **GT-3?** C2ER (Council for Community and Economic Research) Q3 2023 cost-of-living index: Portland scored ~119 (19% above the national average), ranked less expensive than San Jose, San Francisco, Oakland, Los Angeles and San Diego in the same index — cited to C2ER via an Axios (Nov 2023) summary — reported-by-delegate: supplied by a WebSearch synthesis; neither the C2ER data nor the Axios article was opened directly by this analysis.
- **GT-4?** "Paycheck Tax Calculator" cost-of-living benchmark: Portland = 108, San Francisco = 165 (San Francisco ~53% costlier) — reported-by-delegate: supplied by a WebSearch synthesis; the source page was not opened directly.
- **GT-5?** Bay Area hybrid-work trend: a Bay Area Council employer poll indicates 3 days/week in-office is becoming the stated norm; an October 2025 poll found 63% of Bay Area workers now back in the office full time; Amazon requires 5 days/week; Google and Apple maintain hybrid policies; Stanford economist Nicholas Bloom finds most tech workers want 2-3 remote days — reported-by-delegate: supplied by a WebSearch synthesis of several news items, none opened directly by this analysis.
- **GT-6?** Large tech employers (e.g. Meta) generally require employees to work from their assigned office; relocating to work from a different office is possible via internal transfer but is not the default arrangement — reported-by-delegate: supplied by a WebSearch synthesis; the underlying policy pages were not opened directly.
- **GT-7** California 2025 state income tax brackets (single filer): ten brackets from 1% to 13.3%, with the 13.3% top rate starting at $1,000,000; Oregon 2025 state income tax brackets (single filer): four brackets from 4.75% to 9.9%, with the 9.9% top rate starting at $125,000 — source: brackets.tax, "california-vs-

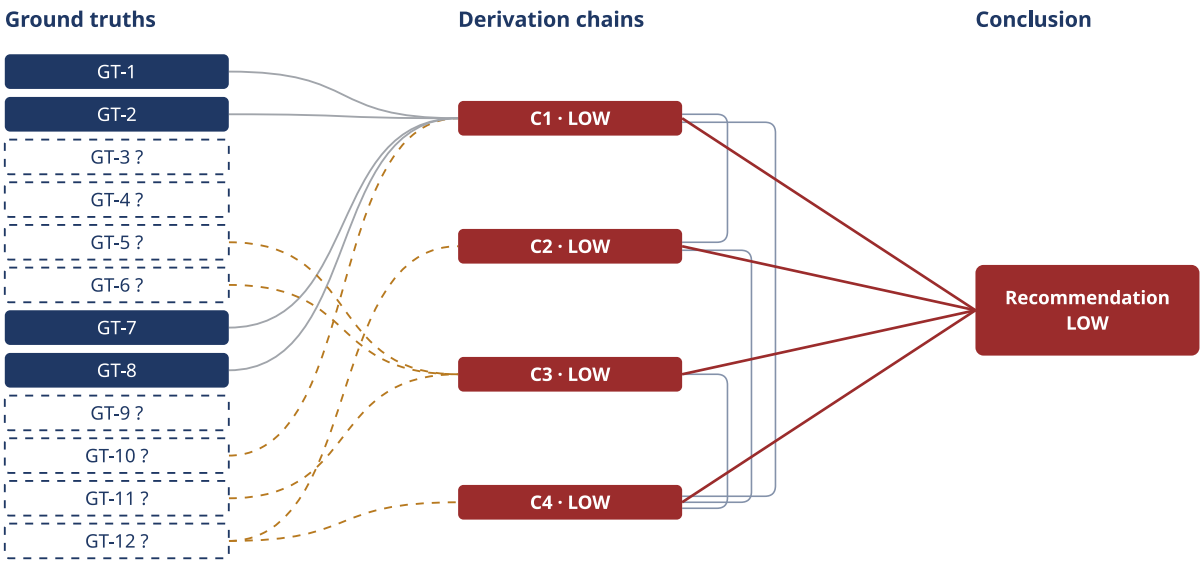
oregon/2025" comparison page; read-at-source: full bracket tables for both states, fetched and read directly.

- **GT-8** At $100,000 single-filer income, modeled combined federal+state income tax (post standard deduction, excluding FICA) is lower in California ($18,657) than in Oregon ($21,641) — a $2,984/yr difference favoring California; at $200,000, California ($51,575) remains lower than Oregon ($54,839) — a $3,264/yr difference favoring California — source: brackets.tax, same page; read-at-source: "Comparison at single-filer salaries" section, fetched and read directly. Label: a modeled calculator estimate, not an audited figure for any specific household or filing status.
- **GT-9?** User-stated premise: the user is a software engineer, 5 years at their current employer, based in Portland, OR, in a fully remote role — the user's own direct statement; no external source named.
- **GT-10?** User-stated premise: the new offer is +$70,000/yr total compensation (base plus equity) above current pay — the user's own direct statement; no external source named.
- **GT-11?** User-stated premise: the new role requires relocating to the SF Bay Area and working in-office 3 days/week (hybrid) — the user's own direct statement; no external source named.
- **GT-12?** User-stated premise: the user's partner has an established, Portland-based career with no remote option for that career — the user's own direct statement; no external source named.

Provenance summary. ?-marked: GT-3, GT-4, GT-5, GT-6, GT-9, GT-10, GT-11, GT-12 (8 of 12). Read-at-source: GT-1 — movenumbers.com, "Overall cost of living index" table; GT-2 — movenumbers.com, "Housing/rent figures" section; GT-7 — brackets.tax, California and Oregon 2025 bracket tables; GT-8 — brackets.tax, "Comparison at single-filer salaries" section.

Note on GT-9? through GT-12?: these are the user's own first-hand facts about their situation, not external claims this analysis could independently audit. They are the scenario's premises, carried with the `?` suffix per the Input Contract's classification rule (a stated fact naming no source enters as unverified) — the suffix flags "not independently verified by this analysis," not "doubted."

4. Derivation Chains



Solid = read at source · dashed = not read at source (?) · fill = confidence · amber dashed = unverified input

Conclusion C1: The user's individual-level real purchasing-power gain is positive and materially smaller than the $70,000 headline, but the "California taxes will eat the raise" convention is false at this income level

Estimate procedure applied (Phase 4 companion technique). Target quantity: Δ real annual disposable income ($/yr), SF offer vs. Portland status quo, for the user individually. Unit-factors: gross comp delta (GT-10?) + state/federal tax delta (GT-7, GT-8) − housing cost delta (GT-2) − other cost-of-living delta (GT-1, bounded estimate for non-housing spend, no single source — bracketed conservatively at $5,000-$8,000/yr). Central multiply-through: $70,000 + ~$3,000 (tax) − ~$20,000 (housing) − ~$6,500 (other COL) ≈ $46,500/yr. Bracket: lower bound $70,000 + $2,984 − $22,000 − $8,000 = $42,984; upper bound $70,000 + $3,264 − $18,000 − $5,000 = $50,264 → **$43,000 to $50,000/yr**. Decision-resolution check: both ends of the bracket are clearly positive and clearly smaller than the $70,000 headline, so the bracket resolves the narrow question it was built for (is the raw delta real after COL/tax, at the individual level?) without needing to be tightened further.

GT-10? (70K gross comp delta, user-stated) + GT-7 (CA 2025 vs OR 2025 state tax brackets, read at source) + GT-8 (CA combined tax lower than OR's at $100K and $200K single-filer income, read at source) + GT-2 (SF-Portland modeled 2BR rent delta ~$20,040/yr, read at source) + GT-1 (SF-Portland overall cost-of-living gap ~34%, read at source) → the popular belief that relocating to California increases the user's state tax burden is false at this income band, because Oregon's compressed brackets tax the same income more heavily than California's broader lower brackets → the $70,000 gross delta is therefore not eroded by state tax, and plausibly nets back roughly $3,000/yr instead *[Assumes: A-13 — the $70,000 is an ongoing annual run-rate, not a one-time bonus; if it were a one-time figure instead, this whole chain's premise changes and the comparison would need to be redone against an annualized equivalent]* → but SF's higher cost of living visibly offsets much of that gain: comparable housing alone costs roughly $20,000/yr more in SF than in Portland, with further non-housing cost-of-living increases on top → netting the gross raise, the favorable tax effect, and the housing/cost-of-living premium against each other yields an estimated $43,000 to $50,000/yr of genuine added purchasing power for the user individually, before equity-liquidity risk (GT-10?, A-9) is taken into account

Confidence: LOW — two axes are short. Inputs: GT-10? is unverified — the headline $70,000 figure's base/equity split and vesting schedule are unconfirmed; obtaining the actual offer letter's grant and vesting terms would remove this as a cause of the downgrade. Inference: the second hop rests on the declared premise A-13 (that $70,000 is an ongoing run-rate, not a one-time bonus); if that premise failed, the endpoint would not stand as computed — it would need to be rebuilt against an annualized equivalent figure, which this analysis has not done, so the failure is not one the endpoint survives. Verification: confirming the offer letter states an ongoing annual figure, not a signing bonus or front-loaded grant, would remove this cause. Rival reading, left live and unsettled by this analysis: the equity portion may be illiquid/at-risk and should be discounted toward zero for comparison purposes, which would pull the true liquid-cash delta well below the $43,000-$50,000 bracket; nothing in this analysis rules that reading out.

Conclusion C2: The partner's career outcome, not the user's own raise, is the dominant swing factor in the household-level financial verdict

C1 (individual net gain ~$43,000-$50,000/yr, LOW) + GT-12? (partner's established Portland career, no remote option, user-stated) → C1′s individual-level gain says nothing about the household's total income if the partner's career cannot continue in the Bay Area → whether "no remote option" means the role itself cannot be performed remotely, or merely that it has never been offered remotely, is unverified — and the two readings carry very different financial consequences (A-2) → if the partner's income is lost or substantially reduced by relocation, the household can come out behind even though the user's own individual math (C1) is positive, because a lost professional income commonly exceeds $43,000-$50,000/yr *[Assumes: A-14 — if lost, the partner's income plausibly exceeds the user's net individual gain; unconfirmed, since the partner's field and income are unspecified]* → the single unknown that most changes the household's financial verdict is therefore not the user's raw raise, but whether and how the partner's income survives the move

Confidence: LOW — two axes are short: Inputs (GT-12? is unverified and C1 is itself only LOW, so the Inputs ceiling is LOW) and Inference (the A-14 premise on this chain's third hop is not priced — this analysis has no data on the partner's actual field or income with which to test it). Verification: a direct conversation establishing (a) exactly what "no remote option" constrains and (b) the partner's actual income and its portability would remove both causes; no external source can supply this. Rival reading, left live: the user's own long-run career-growth value (chain C3) might matter more than a one-time partner-income disruption, so partner impact should not necessarily dominate the decision — this analysis does not settle that trade either way.

Conclusion C3: The offer's 3-day hybrid cadence is not a stable long-term feature, which makes full relocation the least reversible of the available paths

GT-11? (relocation and 3-day in-office requirement, user-stated) + GT-5? (Bay Area RTO cadence trending toward more in-office days, reported-by-delegate) + GT-6? (employers generally require working from the assigned office; transfer possible but not default, reported-by-delegate) → the 3-day hybrid cadence being offered today is not a stable long-term feature of Bay Area tech employment — multiple employers in the same market have moved from hybrid toward full in-office within the same period → committing to physical relocation on the assumption that 3 days/week will remain the ceiling is therefore riskier than the offer letter implies → a trial arrangement that defers full relocation — a commuter structure, or an explicit, dated re-evaluation point — preserves the option to back out before the partner's career sacrifice becomes sunk, at the cost of added logistics and travel burden *[Assumes: A-4 — a commuter/trial arrangement is logistically and financially viable, and the employer would permit it; unconfirmed]* →[2nd] if the broader Bay Area RTO trend (GT-5?) reaches this specific employer during the user's tenure, the 3-day cadence that made relocation seem survivable today could become 5 days within a few years, after the partner's career sacrifice is already sunk *[actor lens: the employer's incentives shift as peers tighten RTO; time lens: a risk invisible at the 1-year horizon and dominant at the 3-5 year horizon]* →[3rd] a policy change like that would convert what was framed as a hybrid decision into a full-relocation decision retroactively, with no guarantee of a corresponding renegotiation of comp or an exit option that doesn't cost the household what it has already given up *[Assumes: A-15 — no renegotiation, grandfathering, or exit accommodation would be offered if cadence tightens later; unconfirmed]*. This does not contradict GT-11? (which describes today's offer terms, not a permanent guarantee), so no return to Phase 2 is triggered.

Confidence: LOW — multiple inputs are `?`-marked (GT-11?, GT-5?, GT-6?) and the A-4 and A-15 premises on this chain are not priced. Verification: asking the employer directly for a written cadence commitment with a stated notice period for any change would remove GT-11?/GT-6? as causes; GT-5? describes an industry trend rather than a single verifiable fact about this employer, so no single verification fully removes it — the practical mitigation is the written commitment itself, not resolving the trend. Rival reading, left live: even if cadence tightens later, the user may by then have other options (internal transfer, another job), so the reversibility risk may be overstated — this analysis does not settle that.

Conclusion C4: Across five viable options, scored on seven weighted criteria, a negotiated or deferred-relocation path dominates — but its top score is conditional on an uncertain negotiation outcome

Trade-off analysis applied (Phase 4 companion technique).

Options (status quo and composites included, per the trade-off procedure's step 1):

- O1 — Accept as offered: full relocation, in-office 3 days/week.
- O2 — Decline: stay in the current fully-remote Portland role (status quo).
- O3 — Counter-negotiate: accept only if the employer grants fully-remote or a reduced in-office cadence, or a delayed/trial start; falls back to O2's profile if refused.
- O4 — Accept via a commuter/dual-household trial: the user relocates near the office, the partner stays in Portland, with a pre-agreed reassessment date.
- O5 — Decline this offer, but use it as leverage for an internal counteroffer (raise, promotion, or remote flexibility) at the current employer.

Must-haves (step 2): no must-have knocks out any of the five options outright at this stage. The one binding procedural constraint — no option should be executed without the partner's informed, explicit agreement — applies equally to all five and eliminates none of them.

Criteria & weights (locked before scoring, step 3-4):

Criterion	Weight	1 means…	5 means…
Net financial upside, COL/tax-adjusted	4	net loss or breakeven	net gain >$40K/yr with high confidence
Partner's career continuity	5	career effectively restarts from zero	career fully continues unaffected
Reversibility / optionality	4	essentially irreversible within 1-2 yrs	fully reversible within months, low cost
Relationship risk	5	high probability of serious strain	minimal added strain
Career growth value of new role	3	lateral, no new scope/brand	major step up
Preserves quality of life / community	3	large loss (network, flexibility, affordability)	fully preserved
Negotiating leverage gained regardless of outcome	2	offer wasted, no leverage	leverage captured either way

Scoring (step 5-7). Cells marked with a GT cite a fact this analysis established; cells with no GT cite are the analyst's preference-based reading of the stated facts (flagged A-16) and should be re-scored by the user against their own judgment.

Option	Financial (×4)	PartnerCont (×5)	Reversibility (×4)	RelRisk (×5)	CareerGrowth (×3)	QoL (×3)	Leverage (×2)	Total
O1 Accept as offered	3→12 (C1)	2→10 (pref.)	2→8 (C3)	2→10 (pref.)	4→12 (pref.)	1→3 (GT-1,GT-2)	2→4 (pref.)	**59**
O2 Decline	1→4 (pref.)	5→25 (GT-12?)	5→20 (pref.)	4→20 (pref.)	2→6 (pref.)	5→15 (pref.)	1→2 (pref.)	**92**
O3 Counter-negotiate	5→20 (C1, conditional)	5→25 (pref.)	5→20 (pref.)	4→20 (pref.)	4→12 (pref.)	5→15 (pref.)	5→10 (pref.)	**122**
O4 Commuter trial	3→12 (C1, minus dual-household cost)	5→25 (pref.)	4→16 (pref.)	2→10 (pref.)	4→12 (pref.)	3→9 (pref.)	2→4 (pref.)	**88**
O5 Decline + leverage	3→12 (pref., conditional)	5→25 (pref.)	5→20 (pref.)	4→20 (pref.)	2→6 (pref.)	5→15 (pref.)	5→10 (pref.)	**108**

Ranking: O3 (122) > O5 (108) > O2 (92) > O4 (88) > O1 (59).

Flip test: O3 beats O5 only on Financial (diff 2×weight4=8) and CareerGrowth (diff 2×weight3=6), a combined margin of 14. Because O3 meets or ties O5 on every other criterion, no single-criterion weight change within the 1-5 scale can close this gap — lowering either weight to its floor of 1 only shrinks the margin to 4, never crosses zero. **No single weight change flips O3 vs. O5.** This ranking is robust to how the weights are set.

But the ranking is not robust to whether O3's central premise holds. O3's Financial and CareerGrowth scores are conditional on the employer actually granting remote or reduced-cadence terms. If that request is refused, O3 degenerates to O2's profile (Financial 1, CareerGrowth 2), and its total collapses to 92 — tied with O2, and well below O5's 108. The trade-off's real output is therefore sequential, not a single static ranking.

C1 (individual net gain ~$43,000-$50,000/yr) + C2 (partner-income swing factor dominates) + C3 (cadence instability, low reversibility) + GT-12? (partner's no-remote-option career) → weighted totals: O3=122 > O5=108 > O2=92 ≈ O3-if-refused=92 > O4=88 > O1=59, driven by Financial and CareerGrowth, robust to weighting but not to O3's negotiation outcome → seeking the negotiated/deferred-relocation path first captures nearly all of the financial and career upside while avoiding the relocation risk this analysis scores

worst → if that negotiation fails, declining while explicitly using the offer as leverage with the current employer (O5) is the strongest fallback, not reverting by default to full acceptance → accepting the relocation exactly as offered (O1) scores weakest under every criterion weighting this analysis tried, because it alone combines low reversibility, the least partner-career certainty, and the largest quality-of-life loss

Confidence: LOW — this chain cites C1, C2 and C3, all LOW, which caps it at LOW regardless of the arithmetic's own robustness (see their own confidence lines for what would remove those causes). In addition, several of this chain's own scoring cells (A-16) are preference-based rather than GT-backed; the verification path for those is for the user to re-score Financial, PartnerCont, RelRisk and QoL against their own judgment and re-run the arithmetic, which this analysis cannot do on their behalf. Rival reading, left live: a straightforward "accept as offered, figure out the partner's situation afterward" (O1) could still be the right call if the user has strong private confidence the partner will adapt — this analysis does not rule that out, and the weighted model should not be read as having settled it.

5. Abandoned Reasoning

Dead End: Treating "decline" (O2) as automatically dominant because it carries zero immediate risk

What was tried: An early framing scored the status quo as trivially safe — zero financial risk, zero relocation risk — and nearly left it unscored as an implicit default winner.

Why abandoned: This is exactly the failure mode the trade-off procedure warns against: an option that scores well on safety criteria can still fail the thing it is implicitly being chosen *for* (here, not missing a rare high-leverage opportunity or quietly resenting having never tried). Scoring O2 on the same seven criteria as every other option (chain C4) showed it is a solid but not dominant option — it ranks third, behind both the negotiated path (O3) and decline-plus-leverage (O5).

What it ruled out: This saves the reader from treating "just say no" as a free, self-evidently safe default that needs no further scoring — it has real costs too (chain C4's Financial and Leverage columns for O2), just different ones than accepting does.

Dead End: Estimating the partner's income loss with a specific dollar figure

What was tried: An attempt was made to size the partner's potential income loss using a plausible median salary for an unspecified "established career," so chain C2 could state a single comparable dollar figure against C1's $43,000-$50,000/yr individual gain.

Why abandoned: The partner's field, role, and seniority were never specified by the user — not even broadly (e.g. medicine, law, education, skilled trade, the arts, government). Any number produced here would be fabricated, not estimated: there is no first-principles value or direct measurement to anchor it to, which is exactly what the Estimate procedure's own discipline forbids substituting with a guess. Reporting a fake-precise figure would mislead by implying a certainty this analysis does not have.

What it ruled out: This prevents the analysis from handing the user a specific "household net impact: $X" number that looks rigorous but rests on nothing — chain C2 instead names the unknown itself (the partner's actual income and its portability) as the load-bearing question, which is the honest and more useful output.

Dead End: Treating a commuter/"mega-commute" arrangement as a confirmed, low-cost alternative

What was tried: An early pass treated "live in Portland, fly to the Bay Area 3 days a week" as an established, generally-available pattern in tech, by analogy to widely-discussed remote/hybrid arrangements elsewhere in the industry, and nearly used it as a settled input to chain C3.

Why abandoned: A targeted search found no citation confirming this specific employer permits a distributed/commuter arrangement, and the actual logistics cost (flights, time, fatigue, dual-location

expense) was never quantified. Treating an industry pattern as proof for this specific offer is analogy used as direct evidence, which D-07 prohibits — any reference to how others have arranged similar situations must be grounded in a verified ground truth about *this* situation, not offered as standalone justification.

What it ruled out: This keeps the commuter arrangement (A-4) correctly flagged as an untested belief to be asked about directly, rather than quietly assumed into chain C3 as if it were already available — which would have understated O4's real feasibility risk and overstated the ease of preserving optionality.

6. Conclusion

Recommended approach: Treat this as a sequence, not a single accept/decline choice: first attempt to negotiate remote work, a reduced in-office cadence, or a delayed/trial start on the existing offer, since that path captures nearly all of the financial and career upside while avoiding the relocation risk that scores worst of the five options tested (chain C4). If that negotiation is refused, decline while explicitly using the offer as leverage with the current employer (chain C4) rather than reverting by default to full, unconditional relocation — accepting the offer exactly as given (chain C4) is the weakest-scoring option under every criterion weighting this analysis tried, and that weakness is driven mainly by the partner's career continuity and relationship-risk criteria (chains C2, C4), not by the financial case alone (chain C1).

Key insight: The popular assumption that "California will eat your raise in taxes" is false at this income level — Oregon's compressed tax brackets actually tax the same income more heavily than California's broader ones, so the $70,000 headline is not substantially eroded by state tax (chain C1). That means the real swing factor isn't the tax bite or even the raw raise — it's what happens to the partner's income and career if the household relocates, which chain C2 identifies as the single most load-bearing unknown in the entire decision, well ahead of the compensation math most people would reflexively scrutinize first.

Trade-offs acknowledged: Pursuing the negotiated or decline-plus-leverage paths sacrifices the career-visibility upside of a full, committed relocation inside a company whose industry is trending toward tighter in-office requirements over time (chain C3's second-order extension) — if the user later wants the on-site, high-visibility version of this role, that door may close. The negotiation can also simply fail, in which case this analysis's own numbers show the top-ranked option's score collapsing to roughly match plain decline (chain C4) — the recommendation is not a guaranteed win, only the best-scoring opening move available with the facts given. No chain in this analysis resolves whether the relationship itself can sustain the stress of any of these paths, or whether the partner's "no remote option" constraint is as absolute as stated — those are the two inputs no external source can supply (chain C2; no chain — flagged assumption only).

Confidence: LOW — this rating matches the weakest chains it rests on rather than averaging them upward. C1 is LOW because GT-10? is unverified (the comp figure's base/equity split and vesting are unconfirmed) and because the declared A-13 premise on that chain is not priced — obtaining the actual offer letter's terms would remove both causes. C2 is LOW because GT-12? is unverified and because the A-14 premise (that a lost partner income would exceed the user's own net gain) is not priced against any actual data on the partner's field or income — a direct conversation establishing both would remove this cause. C3 is LOW because GT-11?, GT-5? and GT-6? are all unverified and the A-4/A-15 premises on that chain are not priced — a written cadence commitment from the employer, with a stated notice period for any change, would remove the GT-11?/GT-6? causes; GT-5? describes an industry trend rather than a single fact about this employer and has no single verification path, which the written commitment mitigates rather than resolves. C4 inherits all of those causes through its head citation and adds its own: several of its scoring cells (A-16) are the analyst's preference-based reading of the stated facts rather than measured facts, and the user should re-score those cells against their own judgment before treating the ranking as settled. This LOW rating is the calibrated result of an honestly incomplete input set, not a hedge — the facts given genuinely do not yet support a higher-confidence verdict.